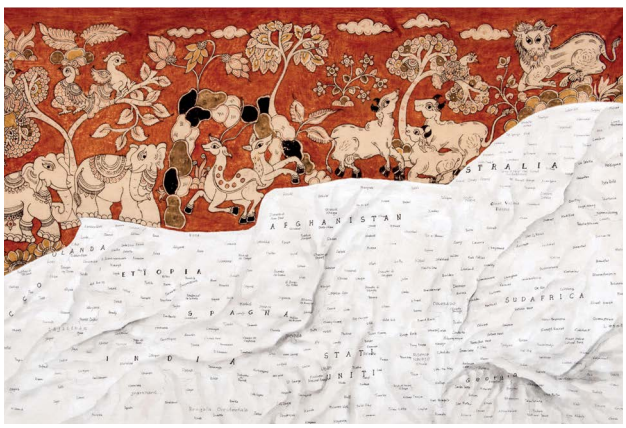
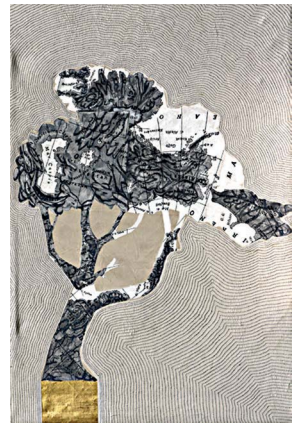


JOINT EFFORTS
Strippoli's collaborations with various artists, on display at *Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam*







EXHIBITION

Mapping the World

Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam, an exhibition by **Tarshito N. Strippoli** at the Bihar Museum, imagines a world where borders are fluid

Tarshito N. Strippoli's solo exhibition, titled *Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam: The World Is One Family*, on display at Bihar Museum, Patna, till December 31, brings together 'map artworks' that the Italian artist has created in collaboration with indigenous artists from around the world, including India. The exhibition has been curated by Tunty Chauhan, Founder, Threshold Art Gallery.

Born Nicola Strippoli in 1952, he was given the name 'Tarshito', meaning 'seeker of inner knowledge', by his guru Osho, whom he met on his first trip to India in 1979. "I left Italy with the ship to Greece and crossed Turkey, Persia, Afghanistan and Pakistan to arrive in India, where I stayed for six months," he says.

At the heart of the exhibition, quite obviously, is the idea of collaboration. As for the process, Strippoli illustrates it with an Indian example: "In Bhopal, I brought seven works with details of seven sacred Indian rivers where I painted the outside with the concept of the united Planet Earth, mixing all nations to abolish borders. And every Indian artist, in this case Gond artists, painted inside the river." In fact, Strippoli started his collaborative art method—"the work made by four hands"—in India, and his first major exhibition here was at the Craft Museum in Delhi in 2001.

The fluid artworks don't adhere to strict timelines in their creation. "Sometimes the realisation takes months, for example, *Walking in Orissa*, the large 10-metre-long roll, represents a coast of the New United World, where the Italian side was made by me and the Indian side by Puspa Rao, a traditional painter of pattachitra," says Strippoli.

For curator Tunty Chauhan, Strippoli's "series of creating new versions of maps and countries without borders is pertinent in our strife-torn world." "The harmony and synthesis of his collaborations are beyond the artistic language he has evolved. It comes from a deep understanding of universal brotherhood," she adds. Curating the exhibition was a learning experience for Chauhan. "My knowledge of indigenous practices was superficial. After spending time with Tarshito, especially in his studio in Bari, Italy, I realised the depth of his practice," she says.

Strippoli started his collaborative art method in India, and his first major exhibition here was at Delhi's Craft Museum in 2001

Although this exhibition only shows paintings, Strippoli works across a variety of media and disciplines, from design to architecture, textile art, jewellery, sculpture and ceramics. On the influence of Osho, he says, "During a conference, Osho said, '....I don't see why there should be so many tracks on geographical maps, the world has not been created with borders.' Listening to these words opened up my vision."

While Strippoli feels there is no overt message in the paintings, Chauhan has a different take. "I think the message is in the path Tarshito has chosen—to share his artistic space with inheritors of the past....Contemporary art is driven by the artist making his statement. Tarshito has abdicated that space." ■

Amit Dixit